would like to own homes. The men were advised to choose places where there was an army cantonment nearby so that they could avail of their entitled medical and canteen facilities, and where they would have schools for the children. Today, it gives me satisfaction to see that many more such projects have been completed or are under construction in Belgaum, Pune, Allahabad, Secunderabad, Dehradun, Bhatinda and Lucknow, besides another one in Jaipur.

The Army Group Insurance Fund (AGIF), which was registered as a society in January 1976, has grown in an impressive manner, thanks to the dedicated and selfless services of officers who managed it, in particular the late Lieutenant General (Honorary) K. Chandrasekharan. Today, it provides an insurance cover to the officers and other ranks of an amount of Rs 30 lakhs and Rs 15 lakhs respectively. Post-retirement, an extended insurance scheme of Rs 4 lakhs for officers, and Rs 2 lakhs for other ranks has also been introduced. During my tenure as COAS, we took a principled stand to protect the nature and identity of this institution when the government wanted to bring it under its regulatory control. AGIF has been providing outstanding services and schemes. It remains professionally managed and is operated with considerable financial prudence.

Army Welfare Education Society (AWES) was instituted by COAS General K.V. Krishna Rao during the early 1980s to meet the educational needs of the children of army personnel. Due to the expansion of the army in 1962, the existing Kendriya Vidyalayas (Central Schools) could not meet the demand and there were no schools in some of the army stations. The AWES, which started with a modest beginning of twenty-eight schools, runs 127 army schools today. The year 1994 was yet another milestone when General B.C. Joshi, the then COAS, took a bold decision to set up our first professional college, the Army Institute of Technology (AIT), in Pune. This indeed was an inspiring concept. The AWES added almost one professional institute every year and now has thirteen colleges or institutions. The AWES has thus filled a major void by providing avenues to our wards to join professional colleges for higher education. We had overlooked the need for such institutions